

TOWER SHELLS AND RELATIVES

These tall-spined snails typically live in muddy or sandy sediment. They feed on particles in the water that they circulate through their mantle cavity. The Cerithioidea are found in marine, freshwater, and estuarine habitats. They are slow moving and often group together in very large numbers.



2.5–5.5 cm
1–2¼ in

GREAT SCREW SHELL

Turritella terebra

F: Turritellidae

A filter feeder of muddy sediments, this Indo-Pacific snail belongs to a group variously known as tower shells or auger shells.

ROUGH CERITH

Rhinoclavis aspera

F: Cerithiidae

Ceriths are snails often abundant in shallow-water tropical marine sediments. Like others, this Indo-Pacific species lays strings of eggs attached to solid material.

WEST INDIAN WORM SHELL

Vermicularia spirata

F: Turritellidae

Free-floating males of this Caribbean unwound screw shell attach to solid material, often embedding themselves in sponges. They then develop into larger sedentary females.



6–17 cm
2¾–6½ in

2.5–16 cm
1–6½ in

PERIWINKLES, WHELKS, AND RELATIVES

The largest and most diverse order of marine snails, the Caenogastropoda are divided into several groups. Epitoniids, including wentletraps (bottom-living) and violet snails (floating), are specialist predators of cnidarians. Littorinids graze on algae, and include periwinkles, cowries, and conches. Whelks and their relatives are predators that project a long siphon out through a groove in the shell.



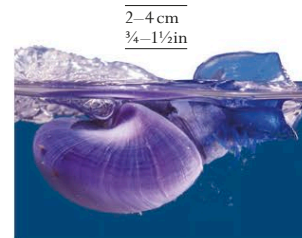
2.5–7 cm
1–2¾ in

PRECIOUS WENTLETRAP

Epitonium scalare

F: Epitoniidae

Wentletraps (from the German for spiral staircase) prey on anemones and corals and have cutting jaws. This is an Indo-Pacific species.



2–4 cm
¾–1½ in

LARGE VIOLET SNAIL

Janthina janthina

F: Epitoniidae

Violet snails float in tropical waters, preying on floating cnidarians. They secrete mucus to create rafts of bubbles that keep them buoyed up.

TIGER COWRIE

Cypraea tigris

F: Cypraeidae

The fleshy lobes of a cowrie's mantle wrap right around the smooth shell when it crawls. This Indo-Pacific species preys on other invertebrates.



10–15 cm
4–6 in

ATLANTIC SLIPPER LIMPET

Crepidula fornicata

F: Calyptraeidae

Unrelated to true limpets, filter-feeding slipper limpets form mating towers, with smaller males on top changing sex to replace dead females beneath.



2–5 cm
¾–2 in



1.5–6 cm
½–2¼ in

FOOL'S CAP

Capulus ungaricus

F: Capulidae

This North Atlantic gastropod resembles unrelated limpets, attaching itself to stones or even the shell of other molluscs, such as scallops.

6–13 cm
2¾–5 in

COMMON PELICAN'S FOOT

Aporrhais pespelecani

F: Aporrhaididae

Cousins of conches, pelican's foot snails are mud-dwelling detritus-eaters with extensions to their shell that look like webbed feet. This species inhabits the Mediterranean and the North Sea.



30–42 cm
12–16½ in



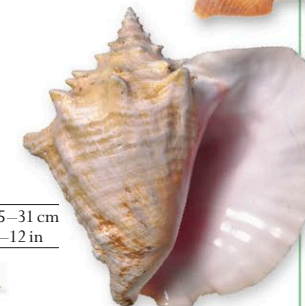
2–3 cm
¾–1¼ in

COMMON PERIWINKLE

Littorina littorea

F: Littorinidae

Periwinkles, such as this European species, form a family of intertidal snails with a globular spired shell closed by an operculum.



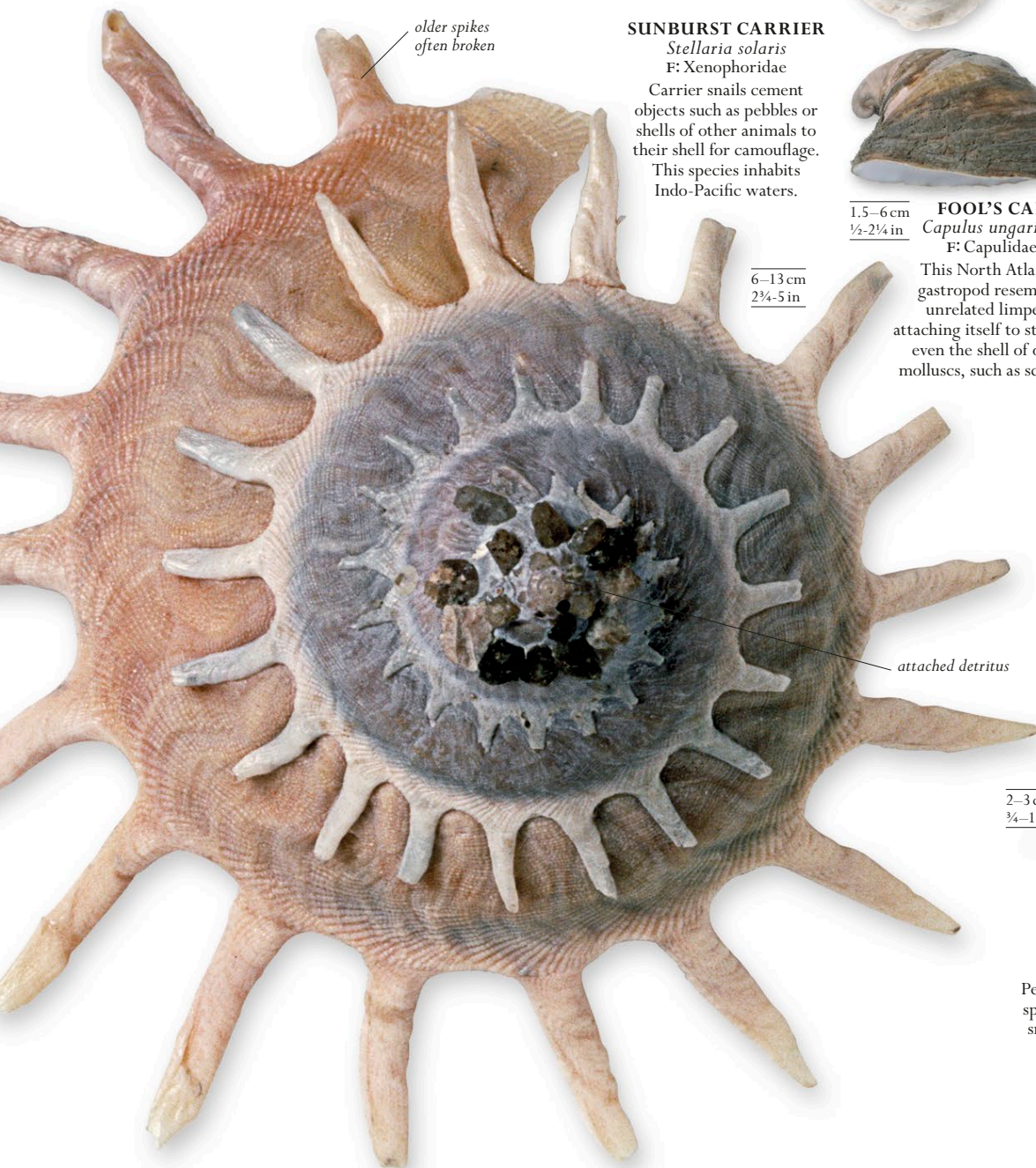
15–31 cm
6–12 in

PINK CONCH

Aliger gigas

F: Strombidae

Conches are mostly tropical, medium to large marine grazing snails. *Strombus* conches, such as this giant W. Atlantic species, have a flare-lipped shell.



SUNBURST CARRIER

Stellaria solaris

F: Xenophoridae

Carrier snails cement objects such as pebbles or shells of other animals to their shell for camouflage. This species inhabits Indo-Pacific waters.

older spikes
often broken

attached detritus